establishment of the Titan company in July 1984, as a joint project of a Tata company called Questar Investments and the Tamil Nadu Industrial Development Corporation Limited (TIDCO). The policy of the Central government to promote joint-sector projects also enabled the Tatas to venture into petrochemicals, an area where it had hitherto had no presence. The first major collaboration was the Karnal refinery project.

The other qualification that JRD desired in a successor was a long tenure. A short tenure would not give a chairman enough time to steer the group to newer horizons, successfully riding the waves of economic reforms. JRD himself had had a long stint at the top and, naturally, he wanted his successor to have one as well.

With age as an important criterion, the number of contenders shrank. All the major aspirants who had been in the reckoning for the post of chairman of TIL, were at least ten years older than Ratan and by the end of 1989, some were no longer alive. Nani Palkhivala was sixty-nine; Russi Mody, seventy-one; Freddie Mehta, sixty-one; none of them would have had a very long tenure. Naval Tata had died in May 1989 of old-age-related complications and Moolgaokar had passed away two months later.

The importance JRD attached to age only increased after the 1991 reforms. He said: ‘Change must provide opportunities for younger people who have shown outstanding courage and enterprise.’ As per the age criterion alone, Ratan, who was just around fifty-two, appeared to have the edge. Perhaps what JRD said in an interview after Ratan’s appointment throws more light on the importance he attached to age. When asked why he had not chosen either Seth or Kerkar, whom he had praised for their work, he said: ‘Darbari [Seth] had tremendous talent and a capacity for work that appals me [sic]. But he is in his seventies. So is Russi Mody [of TISCO], another outstanding leader who is living up to the maxim that a company must get younger year by year by renewing equipment and inducting young talent. Nani Palkhivala [of ACC] is almost in the same age bracket. But Ratan [fifty-three years old at the time] is much younger.’

Besides relatively young age, JRD also looked for ‘courage and enterprise’ in his successor to navigate the group through the choppy waters of economic change. Courage is one of the distinguishing features of the shy and unassuming Ratan. His bold handling of the NELCO and TELCO strikes had confirmed that when the situation demanded, he could be fearless. His refusal to negotiate with Rajan Nair, his persuading the chief